

CHHATRAPATI SHIVAJI MAHARAJ AND HIS PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION

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“One who was the very incarnation of Lord Siva, about whom prophecies were given out long before he was born; and his advent was eagerly expected by all the great souls and saints of Maharashtra as the deliverer of the Hindus from the hands of the Mlecchas, and as one who succeeded in the re-establishment of Dharma which had been trampled underfoot by the depredations of the devastating hordes of the Mughals.”¹

----- Swami Vivekananda on Shivaji

Abstract:

The country is paying homage to Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj as we are celebrating the 350th year of the coronation ceremony of this great Maratha king. The coronation of Shivaji is a special chapter of Indian history as this historic event marked the beginning of the restoration of *Dharma* that instilled the aspiration of self-rule among the people of India. Most importantly, the coronation of Shivaji followed the great tales of good governance, public welfare, and prosperity that inspire us even today. Today in the 350th year of Shivaji's coronation when we are celebrating his legacy, we in this article, have attempted to tell the readers the public administration of Shivaji Maharaj. This article shed light on the governance and administration of Shivaji which makes him one of the greatest rulers of all time.

Introduction

In the annals of history, we come across a few outstanding rulers whose legacies have inspired subsequent generations. One such benevolent ruler is Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaja. He cherished and promoted the values of personal integrity, religious tolerance, patriotism, and public welfare. Besides being a great conqueror and diplomat, he was also an enlightened ruler of his people. The much-celebrated Shivaji's military tactics are one side of his mastermind, while his administrative capacity won him the status of a civil ruler. Contemporary public administrators of India have much to learn from this noble ruler, whom his spiritual teacher **Samarth guru Ramdas** wonderfully described as; “He is like a high mountain in determination. He is the support of many people. He is unflinching in his ideals. He is rich in asceticism. The stream of his good deeds is ever-flowing. How can the greatness of his virtues be compared to others? He is a glorious, victorious, valorous, virtuous, charitable, diplomatic, and wise king. He is devoted to virtue, reason, charity and religion. He is humble, though he is omniscient. He is unwavering, liberal, grave, heroic and ever-ready for action. This best of kings has outdone others in resourcefulness. He is the protector of the gods* religion, cows and Brahmans. In his heart, God has established Himself to inspire him. He supports scholars, Sadhus, poets, and Brahmans who are devoted to sacrifices and philosophers. There is none like him as a protector of religion in this world. If the religion of Maharashtra is somewhat alive now, it is due to him.”²

Shivaji was a popular king who kept a close watch on the administrative affairs of his state. All powers were concentrated on him, but he ruled with the advice of his ministers. The common people regarded him with great devotion and considered him their greatest will-wisher.³ He organised and built civil institutions to achieve the ideal of **Hindavi Swarajya** ("self-rule of Hindu people and independence from foreign rule"). Shivaji's *Hindavi Swaraj* also embodied **Suraj** (good governance) as he introduced reforms in public administration and demonstrated good governance. The success of asserting national independence from the imperial rule of the Mughals and establishing an independent state based on the ancient Hindu concept or the philosophy of *Dharma* owes largely to the civil and administrative institutions he initiated. His administrative system displays originality and breadth to the government systems then prevalent in India.⁴

Most remarkably, Shivaji revived ancient Hindu polity as described in *Mahabharata*, *Dharmashastras*, and *Arthashastra* that the king should reign but not only rule, and rejected the Islamic conception of State based upon intolerance towards other faiths.⁵ Indeed, the administrative reforms made by him for the attainment of *Swarajya* make him one of the greatest statesmen in world history. This was highlighted by our honourable Prime Minister, Shri Narendra Modi, on the auspicious occasion of the 350th year of the coronation ceremony of Shivaji. **Modi Ji** said, “The great tales of ‘*Swaraj*’ (self-rule), ‘*Sushasan*’ (good governance), and ‘*Samridhi*’ (prosperity) that emerged from this chapter of history continue to inspire us even today. The national and public welfare principles remained the foundation of Shivaji Maharaj’s governance. His actions, governance, and policies continue to be relevant today, whether it is about the welfare of farmers, women's empowerment, making governance accessible to ordinary individuals, or his administrative system.”⁶

Shivaji endeavored to revive ancient Hindu polity, best manifested in forming the Council of Eight Ministers called ***Astapradhan***. Each minister was assigned responsibilities as the head of the separate departments. He made no office hereditary. His keen interest in the welfare of the peasantry made him the tallest among all the rulers of medieval India. His revenue administration, discussed in detail in this paper, was as efficient as civic administration in which middlemen were not allowed to oppress ryots. In the judicial system, as we will see later, Shivaji revived ancient laws of the land that suited his time. *Establishing social harmony was an integral part of his body politics.*⁷

Maratha State: Hindavi Swarajya

Following the conquest of India by the Islamic invaders, ancient political institutions decayed, and Hindu traditions dwindled. On 6th June 1674, Shivaji crowned himself at Raigad, declaring that he had thrown off the foreign yoke and become a legally constituted monarch in his own right. With his coronation, a new era called the ‘Rajyabhisheka Era’ commenced in the history of India. Shivaji wanted complete separation from the Mughal Empire. Therefore, he was coronated by a ritual called *Maharajabhishek* or *Indrabhisheka*, a ceremony performed by Indian kings mentioned in the *Aitareya Brahmana* but had fallen into disuse since the loss of political power to the Islamic invaders. Vishveshvara Bhatta, popularly known as Gang Bhatt and renowned as *Vedonarayana* (greatest exponent of Vedic knowledge) of the holy city of Kashi, presided over the coronation of Shivaji. The seven sacred waters of the rivers - Ganga, Yamuna, Sindhu, Godavari, Krishna, and Kaveri contained in a gold vessel held over Shivaji's head by Gang Bhatt, and he chanted the coronation mantras as the holy water kept dripping from the tiny holes in the vessel. After the ablution, Shivaji bowed before his mother **Jijabai**, and touched her feet. Shivaji was bestowed with the sacred thread *jaanva* and was bathed in an *abhisheka* (anointing ceremony). Shivaji was formally crowned *Chhatrapati*, signifying that he was bestowed with the protection of his people.⁸ This coronation began a new era of Hindu political revivalism. Gang Bhatt's following words attest to this: “The forms of Kshatriya duty have been utterly extinguished during the Kali Yuga. The earth is overrun with Yavanas (Islamic invaders) who have usurped the thrones of kings. No spark of valour is left in the warriors of the Solar or the Lunar race. Sacrifices are stopped; forms of duty forgotten; the Brahman Dharma eclipsed; the great shrines have lost their expiatory virtue. It is only you who have put forth great valour, defeated the Mahomedan sultans, quieted Aurangzeb, vanquished his pro-consuls, won a great kingdom, and maintained in your power a hundred thousand cavalries, three hundred and sixty forts, and great wealth and possessions. This being so, you are yet without a consecrated throne. It is, therefore, my wish and the wish of many other people of Sawraj to crown you king and have you saluted as a king of the royal umbrella by other rulers. Without a formal crowning, a ruling king has no honour. By getting yourself formally crowned, you will complete the humiliation of Aurangzeb and the other sultans.”⁹

Shivaji also commissioned a new coinage and regal insignia to detach from foreign Mughal rule completely. For administrative ideas, Shivaji dwelt on the ancient Indian political texts like *Mahabharata*, *Arthashastra*, and *Sukraniti*, where he found that government should be vested in the hands of a council of ministers. The formation of a council of eight ministers popularly known as *Ashtapradhdna* by Shivaji and giving them Sanskrit designations, indeed, was part of his endeavour to revive ancient Hindu political institutions.¹⁰ Thus, the rise of Shivaji also revived ancient Hindu polity. Nevertheless, Shivaji's real genius of practical statesmanship lay in how he successfully

blended ancient Indian political institutions with his contemporary administrative machinery and devised a novel system of administration suited to his times and his people. This system's pivot was the monarch, who both ruled and reigned. He was the supreme executive and legislator, as well as the supreme judge. Overall, the ancient Indian aphorism that the ruler is the marker of his age is found in Shivaji's idea of kingship.¹¹ Contemporary writers considered Shivaji Maharaj an avatar (incarnation). They saw a divine hand in the foundation of *Swarajya*.¹² Considering the almost miraculous achievements of Shivaji, his contemporaries considering him an avatar is unsurprising. But curiously enough, even the contemporary foreign accounts support the avatar theory when they speak of Shivaji in superhuman terms.¹³ The foundation of the Maratha State by Shivaji was a great manifestation of a true national spirit embodied in the concept of *Hindavi Swarajya*. Dharma was perhaps the strongest of the various elements that went into the making of the Maratha nation. As we all know, the **centuries of Muslim rule in India led the common people to live in depressing conditions. Not only their political freedom was lost, but their religion was treated with open disregard.**

In such a milieu of religious persecution, Hindus found rescue in the teaching of the medieval Bhakti saints that swayed all over India. Maharashtra, in particular, saw many saints from all castes, like Shri Chakradhar, Namdeo, Dnyaneshwar, Eknath, Tukaram, Janabai, and Samarth Ramdas (the guru of Shivaji). These saints brought great social and spiritual awakenings and produced a new spirit of democratic equality and homogeneity among the people of Maharashtra. Hindu Dharma was resurrected, and a sense of independence grew. Shivaji was not only inspired by the teachings of great Maharashtra saints but his quest for *Hindavi Swarajya* was also aided by the widespread spiritual and social enlightenment sparked by these saints. Shivaji's guru, Samarth Ramdas, gave a religio-political colour to the Maratha's aspiration of an independent state.¹⁴ Thus, Shivaji came up as Protector of *Dharma* (Righteousness) and welded Maratha territory into a single body politic (*Swarajya*) on the principle of social harmony and peasants' welfare.¹⁵

Shivaji, thus, successfully turned into one patriotic current all the available forces of the time — political, moral, religious, and anti-foreign— to build up a politically independent Maratha Hindu State. The Maratha Hindu State under him could be best described as a national monarchy. However, the Maratha Hindu State was not directed against any religion, although it was intended to propagate the Hindu Dharma. Its basic aim was to preserve and carry forward the ancient Vedic religion and culture of all the people residing in India. Shivaji very well knew that only when the safety and integrity of *Dharma* were secured, the state tended to become more and more prosperous, and Dharma cannot flourish in a kind of state as the Mughal Empire was, nor does a benevolent state be formed where principles of Islam dominate.¹⁶ Thus, it was unsurprising that Shivaji emerged as a staunch Dharma defender in the term's highest sense. It was *Dharma* that formed the root of his *Hindavi Swarajya*.

Shivaji also believed that his kingdom was divinely ordained, and he used his royal authority for the well-being of his people. What makes the Maratha state under Shivaji unique is that in an age of bigotry and ruthlessness, careers were thrown open to talent, and patronage and safety were provided to all the subjects. His efforts were motivated by a desire to improve the lives of his people, regardless of their background.

In his Swarajya, the welfare of the peasantry was greatly emphasised. As landlords were often unjust to the cultivators, he kept them under strict control and did not create any middlemen between the government and the soil tillers. Shivaji's letter dated 16th April 1673, addressed to his revenue officers, speaks volumes about his concern for the common folk in his country. He writes: **"If you rob the poor cultivators of their grain, bread, grass, fuel or vegetables, they will find life impossible and run away. Many will die of starvation. Then they will think you are worse than the Mughals who overrun the countryside. Know this well and behave yourself. You have no business to give the slightest trouble to the ryots. You should purchase anything you want- grain, grass, fuel, vegetables or other provisions — in the bazaar. You do not need to force anybody or quarrel with anybody."**¹⁷

Shivaji's fundamental strength in his quest for *Swarajya* came from the common people of Maharashtra. Although Shivaji's kingdom was not particularly extensive in terms of territory, the real glory and greatness of *Hindavi Swarajya* was essentially due to the ideals for which it stood and the

principles by which it was governed by its great founder. Indeed, Shivaji's domination spread through the conquest of hearts, something only an honest administrator can achieve among a simple rural population. His truly paternalistic approach, strong sense of justice, and genuine care for the welfare of his people drew a significant response from the people of Maratha country. They regarded him as their liberator, emancipator, and protector.¹⁸ The unbounded admiration that the masses had for their beloved hero constituted Shivaji's real strength in founding *Hindavi Swarajya*. Ramchandrapant Amatya, who served as the Finance Minister to Shivaji, accurately reflects the political mind of his *Chhatrapati* (emperor) in his *Adnyapatra* (the formal documentation of Shivaji's ideals, principles, and policies of state administration).¹⁹ He provides us with a clear idea of the essential features of the grand polity of *Hindavi Swarajya*. The cardinal principles on which Shivaji's governance and administration are based were;

- i) To promote the well-being of the people and the general welfare of the State.
- ii) To maintain an efficient military force to defend Swarajya.
- iii) To provide adequately for the economic needs of the people by encouraging agriculture and industry.²⁰

Elements in Hindvi Swarajya: Council of Eight Ministers - Ashtapradhdna

*Shivaji threw careers open to talent and built up small men to achieve great deeds. Therein lay his genius as an administrator. Moro Pant Pingle, a family priest, becomes his Prime Minister; Annaji Datto, a village accountant, rises to be his finance minister. The men trained by Shivaji became the toughest generals in battle and the greatest statesmen in diplomacy. Sonaji Pant Dabir negotiated with Aurangzeb and Sundarji Prabhu with the English. Prahlad Niraji was the Maratha envoy at the court of the Qutb Shah. Shivaji aimed to give equal opportunities to all castes and creeds in his administration system. Thus, fully acknowledging the importance of ministers (Pradhans) in conducting the affairs of the kingdom as recommended in the ancient Sastras, Shivaji and his mother Jija Bai as early as 1642 appointed Shamraj Nilkanth Ranzekar as Peshwa, Balkrishna Pant Hanumante as Mujumdar, Sono Pant as Dahir and Raghunath Ballal as Sabnis. This was the nucleus of what later developed into the famous Council of Eight Ministers called Ashtapradhdna.*²¹ (no need) Dear Sir, I think we should keep this otherwise the paper get short. Also this para traces the origin of Ashtapradhan which the reader should know.

This Council of eight ministers, *Ashtapradhdna*, was not a Cabinet. Shivaji was his own prime minister and kept all the strings of the administration in his own hands. The eight ministers acted as his secretaries and had no initiative or power to dictate his policy. Their function was purely advisory. These ministers mainly supervise the details in their respective departments. It is to be noted that Shivaji never interfered with the ecclesiastical and accounts departments. Shivaji designated his ministers by giving them Sanskrit titles as mentioned in ancient Hindu texts; however, the official letters also carry the old Persian names due to administrative exigencies. Shivaji specified the duties of his eight ministers and other departmental heads. It is worth mentioning that his *Ashtapradhdna* was a portfolio system based on *Sukraniti* (an ancient Hindu treatise on the science of governance). The names and duties of ministers were largely adopted from Sukra's Polity only.²² The eight ministers and their duties were the following:²³

1. *Peshwa* or *Mukhya Pradhan* (Prime Minister): He was in charge of the whole administration of the kingdom. He was to work with the counsel and cooperation of his colleagues. In times of war, he was to bravely lead the army, subjugate new kingdoms, and make necessary arrangements to administrate the newly acquired territories. All state papers and charters had to bear his seal below that of the Chhatrapati.
2. *Amatya* or *Majmuadar* (Finance Minister): He had to check all the accounts of public income and expenditure and report them to the king. He also had to countersign all statements of accounts of the kingdoms in general and the particular districts.
3. *Mantri* or *Waqianavis* (Political Secretary): His duties were to compile a daily record of the king's doings and court incidents and to watch over the king's invitation lists, meals, and companions

to guard against murderous plots. The invitation and intelligence departments were under him. He was also to serve in the war. His seal was to be put on official documents.

4. *Sachiv* or *Shurunavis* (Superintendent): He had to see that all royal letters were drafted properly. He had also to check the accounts of the *mahals* and *Parganas*.

5. *Sumant* or *Dabir* (Foreign Secretary): He was the *Chhatrapati* adviser on relations with foreign states, war, and peace. It was also his duty to keep intelligence about other countries, to receive and dismiss foreign envoys, and to maintain the state's dignity abroad. He was to receive and entertain foreign envoys and maintain the state's dignity abroad.

6. *Senapati* or *Sar-i-Naubat* (Commander-in-Chief): He maintains the army, makes war, and leads expeditions. He should preserve the newly acquired territories, render an account, report to the king the requirements and grievances of the army, and obtain lands and rewards for the meritorious.

7. *Pandit Rao* and *Danadhyaksa* (The Ecclesiastical Head): It was his function to honour and reward learned Brahmans on behalf of the king, to decide theological questions, to fix dates for religious ceremonies, to punish impiety and order penances. He was a Judge of Canon Law, Royal Almoner, and Censor of Public Morals combined.

8. *Nyayadhish* (The Chief Justice): He tried civil and criminal cases according to Hindu law and endorsed all judicial decisions, especially about rights to land, village headmanship, etc.

Revenue System

The concept of an economically prosperous and flourishing people was intrinsic to Shivaji's ideal of *Hindavi Swarajya*. He knew that the first duty of a ruler was to make his people prosper. He strove throughout his life to make his state economically a viable unit. The way Shivaji protected the tillers of the soil and encouraged agriculture, which formed the backbone of Maratha's economy, the keen interest that he showed in developing trade, commerce, and industry in his state, and the various judicious measures that he took to augment the state finances, clearly shows that Shivaji had a good sense of national economy. Thus, not only did Shivaji establish *Hindavi Swarajya*, but he placed it on a stable and solid foundation.²⁴ The splendid achievement of Shivaji is brilliantly summed up by one of his *Astapradhan*, Ramchandrapant Amatya, in a single sentence, “केवळ नूतन सृष्टिटीच निर्माण केली” (He created an altogether new order of things).²⁵

Apart from core Maratha's land, Shivaji's kingdom comprised territories he wrested from the Sultans of Ahmadnagar, Bijapur, and the Mughal emperor. Thus, different revenue systems were prevalent in the Maratha State. In the newly acquired territories, the ryots were formerly subject to patios, Kulkarni, and Deshmukh, who used to do the collection work and pay what they pleased to the state, sometimes only 200 or 300 *hun* for a village yielding 2,000 *hun* as revenue. These hereditary landlords collectively called *mirasdars* were grown powerful to the extent that they never waited upon the revenue officer of Government to collect tax and even urged the village not to pay more to the state. This class who had become unruly very often used to seize the country. But Shivaji dismantled their castles, garrisoned the strong places with his troops, and took away all power from the *mirasdars*. They were brought under control and their dues were fixed after calculating the exact revenue of the village.²⁶ As the welfare of the peasantry was greatly emphasised in Shivaji's ideal of *Hindavi Swarajya*, sweeping out the middleman between him and ryots was his natural policy. Moreover, Shivaji did not make ryots subjected to the authority of the feudal lords such as *deshmukha*, and *deshpandes*, who were not only restrained from interfering in the revenue management of the country but also their right to exercise the powers of a political superior (overlord) over ryots or harassing them was taken away from them.²⁷ Most importantly, Shivaji tried to bring financial unity by establishing one common method for revenue collection. For this, he ordered the surveying of land in every province to assess the rent and other dues payable by the cultivators. The main features of Shivaji's revenue system were (i) the classification of lands according to fertility, (ii) ascertainment of their produce, (iii) fixing the government share, (iv) collection of rents either in kind or money, and (v) abolition of the intermediate collecting agents as farmers of the revenue.²⁸

The Maratha State under Shivaji claimed two-fifths of the land produced, leaving three-fifths to the peasants. Using the Tagai and Istawa principles, new lands were brought under the plough, and the

farmers were subsidized with seeds and cattle. New cultivators were given seeds and cattle, and loans advanced to them were recovered over the years. The cultivable wastelands were excluded when a village was assessed. Whenever some of the wastelands were brought under cultivation, they were taxed moderately to begin with.²⁹ Shivaji warned the officers not to take land tax more than that was fixed and if the harvest was lost owing to severe rains or drought, or if an enemy army devastated the village, remissions were granted in land revenue. Shivaji also asked people to assess their respective villages by themselves along with the revenue officer. This shows that he wanted the participation of even the most downtrodden peasantry in the government. So by removing uncertainties and undue exactions which was the legacy of the Muslim rulers, Shivaji gained the affection and cooperation of the peasants and he became their conspicuous leader.³⁰

The Judicial System

Shivaji had the great ideal of reviving and strengthening Hindu laws and customs. Under the Maratha State, *Sukraniti*, *Yajnavalkya Smriti*, *Vyavahara Mayukha*, and *Kamalakara* were called authorities in legal disputes. In civil suits, the decision was given after consulting the *Mitakshara*. To settle cases of varying nature, many *sabhas* were established as judicial bodies. The most important judicial body was the *Raj Sabha* constituted of the *Chhatrapati*, *Peshwa*, important officers of the kingdom, and persons of the place in which the dispute had arisen. The case of the Kharade brothers versus Kalbhar brothers about the Patilship of village Pali is worthy of mentioning here as it was heard by the council consisting of Shivaji, Peshwa, Nyayadhish, Panditrao, Mujumdar, Senapati, other important officers, Deshmukhs, Deshpandes, and Patils of the village Pali. Here we find the procedure adopted in hearing and deciding suits. It was found that the case could not be decided on the available evidence. Therefore the complainant had to undergo an ordeal. Therein he failed and hence he lost his case.³¹

Among other courts prevalent during the time of Shivaji in Maratha territory were *Dharmasabha*, *Brahman Sabha*, and *Deshak Sabha* deserve mention. The Brahmin Sabha was composed of distinguished scholars of high character. Sometimes scholars from Banaras (Kashi) were invited to decide complicated cases. One of these councils was called by Shivaji to decide his Kshatriya origin and the right to have a coronation with Vedic ceremonies. The Deshak Sabha was generally composed of Deshmukhs, Deshpandes, Patils, Balutas of the villages, and Shete-Mahajans of the towns included in the Pargana. Officers of the Pargana like Hawaldar, Thanedar, Samaubat, Karkun, Sabnis, Chitnis, Karkhanis, Sargrohs, Naikwadis, etc. used to be members of this council. A case relating to several villages was decided by it. If a party was dissatisfied with the decision of the village panchayat, it could request the re-hearing of the case by the Deshak Sabha. Dharmasabha was headed by *Panditrao*, the head of the ecclesiastical department, who had the right to countersign all documents issued by the king relating to Achara, Vyavahara, and Prayaschitta - the three parts of the Dharmashastras. Some revisionary power was vested in the Panditrao; otherwise, he would not give his approval to the decisions of the secular courts.³²

Most importantly, Shivaji conferred a great deal of judicial autonomy upon the people as recommended in the ancient law books of India. According to Sage Sukra, cultivators, artisans, artists, usurers, corporations, dancers, ascetics and thieves should decide their disputes according to the usage of their profession. Thus, Shivaji allowed all civil and even ordinary criminal cases to be decided by people's courts at the local level. In villages, the complainant took his plaint to the Patel who after trying to get the dispute settled through his own influence, called on a few village elders to sit together and hear the parties. The *saraunsh* which was the summary of the evidence was noted by the village G. T. Kulkarni writer and the execution of which was the duty of the *mamladar*. The main object aimed at was amicable settlement and arbitration. If arbitration failed, the case was transferred for a decision to a panchayat, appointed by the Patel in the village and by the *shete mahajan*, or leading merchant in urban areas. An appeal lay from the decision of a panchayat to the mamladar, who usually upheld the verdict unless the parties concerned were able to prove that the panchayat was prejudiced or corrupt. In important suits, however, it was the duty of the *mamlatdar* to appoint an arbitrator, the members of which were chosen by him with the approval and often at the suggestion, of the parties to the suit. In such cases, the panchayat's decision was subject to an appeal to the Peshwa or his legal minister, the

nyaydhish.³³ Thus, the system of panchayats left a good deal of autonomy in the legal administration at the local level.

Conclusion

Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj's legacy endures not only through his military conquests but also through the administrative reforms that continue to inspire us today as a symbol of good governance. We have shown in this paper that Shivaji introduced a council of eight ministers called *Ashtapradhan* which streamlined governance and ensured accountability in bureaucracy. His public administration was characterized by a well-organized system of land revenue and justice that secured the welfare of the people. As we have seen in this paper, Shivaji implemented a revenue system in which the rent was collected directly from the peasants, thus eliminating oppressive intermediaries. Most importantly, he promoted agriculture by offering incentives to farmers, construction of irrigation facilities, and protecting farmers from invaders. Shivaji also ensured local administration in the hands of the local officials who can manage day-to-day affairs. In judicial affairs too, he gave importance to *panchayats* where local disputes were used to be resolved. However, it is to be remembered that Shivaji's public administration was devised to establish *Hindavi Swarajya* which symbolizes a vision of independence from foreign rule, self-reliance, and good governance based on indigenous principles and practices of *Dharma*.

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